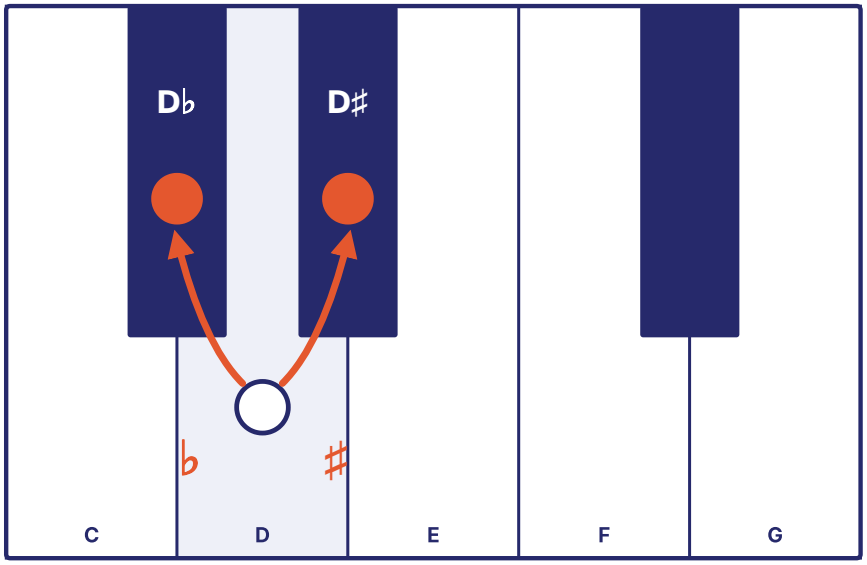
PART I · PITCH · 6

Sharps, flats and naturals

The black keys have no letters of their own. They borrow the names of their white neighbours, adding a sharp or a flat. These signs, and the natural that cancels them, are called **accidentals**.

THE SECRET

Sharp: the very next key to the right. Flat: the very next key to the left.

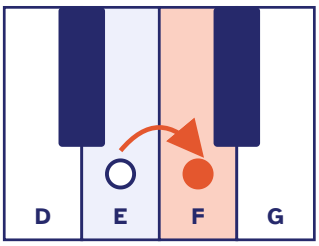


♯ one key right · ♭ one key left

SIGN	NAME	WHAT IT DOES	FIRST MET
♯	sharp	one key to the right (a semitone higher)	Beginner
♭	flat	one key to the left (a semitone lower)	Beginner
♮	natural	cancels a sharp or flat: back to the white key	Prelim

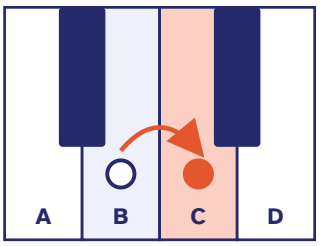
A **semitone** is the smallest step on the piano: from one key to the very next, black or white (American books call it a *half step*). More on p. 42. With no black key between (E–F, B–C), the next key is white: E♯ = F and B♯ = C; F♭ = E and C♭ = B. And every black key has two names: C♯ = D♭.

E♯ = F



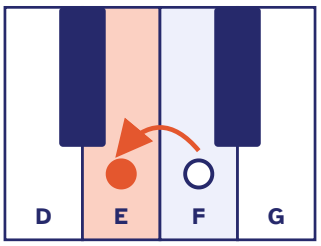
♯ right, no black key between

B♯ = C



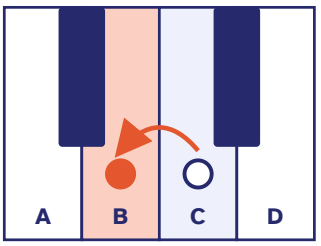
♯ right, no black key between

F♭ = E



♭ left, no black key between

C♭ = B

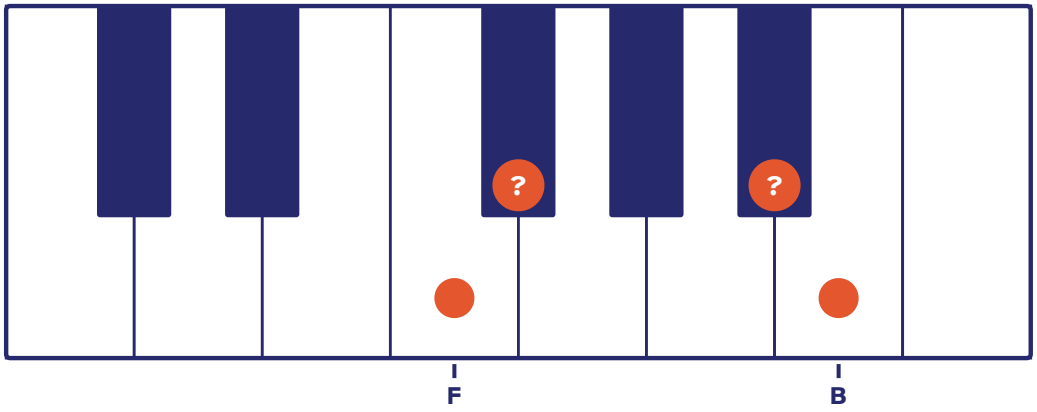


♭ left, no black key between

PART I · PITCH · 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Find F♯ and B♭



1. **Find F and B** (the red dots): F just left of the three black keys, B just right of them.
2. **Sharp means right:** F♯ is the very next key to the right of F.
3. **Flat means left:** B♭ is the very next key to the left of B. Black or white?

The left **?** is **F♯**, the first black key of the three; the right **?** is **B♭**, the highest one, on the right.

THE RULE

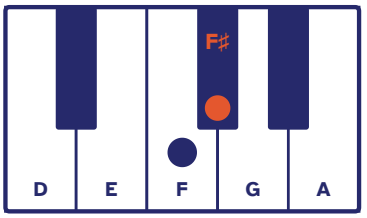
A sign belongs to one line or space. It changes only that line or space, in that octave, and only until the bar line. The same letter in another octave, and every other note, stays as it is.

A **bar** is the space between two **bar lines** (p. 50). A **key signature** at the start of every line is different: it lasts the whole piece (p. 99). And a natural cancels a sharp just as it cancels a flat.

EXAMPLE 2

How long does the sharp last?





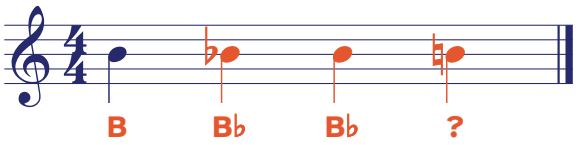
1. **The first note** has a sharp: F♯.
2. **Later in the same bar** there is no sign. Is it still sharp?
3. **After the bar line**: is it still sharp?

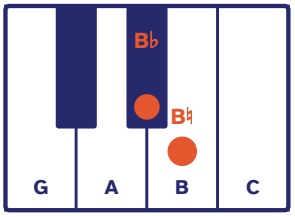
Still **F♯** until the bar line; after it, plain **F** again. A sign lasts **to the end of its bar**.

PART I · PITCH · 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

A natural cancels the flat





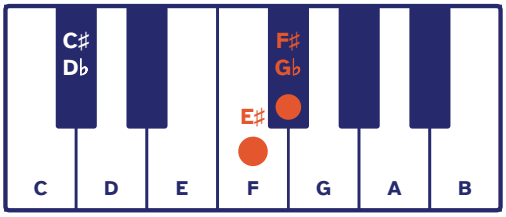
1. **B**: the white key.
2. **B♭**: one key left, and it stays flat for the rest of the bar.
3. **The last note** has a natural sign: what does it do?

The natural **cancels** the flat: back to the white key B, until the bar line.

EXAMPLE 4

One key, two names





1. **The first bar:** F♯, then G♭. Find both on the keyboard.
2. **Are they different keys?**
3. **The last bar:** E♯. Which key is one right of E?

F♯ and G♭ are the **same black key**; E♯ is the white key **F**, so the **?** is plain F, the same key as E♯. Same sound, different names: **enharmonic**. The same trick with no black key between: **B♯** is the white key C, **F♭** is the white key E.

YOU KNOW THIS

Für Elise (Beethoven)



E, **D♯**, E, **D♯**: the next key down and back. The bar line wipes the sharp out, so it is written again; later the D needs a **natural**, or it would still be D♯.

Try it. Play E and D♯ back and forth: the black key just left of E.

THINK OF IT A sharp or flat is a sticky note on one line of the staff: it stays stuck until the bar line, then it falls off.

TRAP

× Carrying a sharp or flat past the bar line: after it, the note is plain again.

SEE ALSO

Keys and key signatures p. 99

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 11–12 · Online: Accidentals · Tones & Semitones